

Breaking down gender stereotypes

Most societies encourage people to behave in a certain way, wear appropriate clothes, and do particular things based on conventional ideas about what it means to be a woman or a man, and to be feminine or masculine. Unfortunately, people who do not conform to these expectations may encounter disapproval from society.

Thinking more broadly about gender allows everybody to express themselves more fully. Gender stereotypes regularly appear in the media and may lead someone to feel there are things they can't or shouldn't do, but nobody should feel limited by social norms, regardless of whether they are male, female, neither, or both.



△ Challenging social norms

Everyone should feel able to achieve their full potential and make their own choices, free from the constraints of gender stereotypes.

Gender dysphoria

For most people, their gender identity matches their biological sex (cisgender). However, for some, the sex they were assigned at birth may not correspond with how they identify or express themselves. Gender dysphoria refers to the emotional distress a person experiences if their body doesn't match their gender identity.

A person with gender dysphoria may feel very uncomfortable with the assumptions society makes about their gender identity based on their biological sex. To match the way they feel inside, some people choose to change their name, their appearance, or their anatomy to align with how they feel.

TEEN HINTS

If you're confused

- Research other people's experiences and thoughts on gender; you're not alone in your questions.
- Talk to someone you trust—a close friend, school counselor, or support group.
- If you feel ready to share and think your parents will support you, find a time when you can talk to them alone. If you are concerned your parents will react negatively, don't feel pressured to tell them—it's okay to wait.

PARENT TIPS

If your teen needs support

- Puberty can be an upsetting time for a person with gender dysphoria, so it's important to listen carefully and take your teen's concerns seriously.
- Find resources, including books, websites, and people to help you learn more.
- Avoid pressuring your teen to behave differently. Remind them it's okay to act in a way that doesn't conform to traditional expectations.

Genderqueer

This is someone whose gender identity does not fall easily into either woman or man; this term covers a wide range of identities.

Questioning

Refers to a person who is reluctant to label themselves while they explore their gender identity.

Gender fluid

A person whose gender identity includes a range of male, female, masculine, and feminine traits. They don't consider their gender to be fixed.

Androgynous

A gender expression that includes approximately equal aspects of both the feminine and the masculine.